Critical Analysis of Interface

(Be Minimalist)

UX / HCI Interface Evaluation — D2C Skincare E-commerce

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Website Chosen

Field	Details
Website	Be Minimalist (Minimalist)
Official website analysed	https://beminimalist.co/
Primary interfaces reviewed	Home page, header search and navigation, category filters, product cards, product detail page (PDP), cart drawer, and footer links.

Introduction

User interface design plays an important role in online shopping, especially for personal care and skincare products where customers need to understand active chemical ingredients and formulations before making a purchase. This assignment presents a critical analysis of the **Be Minimalist** website using standard Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) and usability engineering principles.

The evaluation assesses the website across **ten core interface parameters**: Learnability, Navigation Structure, Usability & Efficiency, Visual Hierarchy, Consistency, Error Prevention & Recovery, Feedback & System Status, Accessibility & Readability, Trust & Transparency, and Aesthetic & Minimalist Design. Each parameter is rated out of 10 with observed strengths, issues, and suggested improvements. The findings are then cross-evaluated against Shneiderman’s Eight Golden Rules.

Overview

Be Minimalist is a leading Indian direct-to-consumer (D2C) skincare brand. Unlike traditional cosmetic brands that rely on vague claims, Be Minimalist names its products directly after active ingredients and their concentrations (such as Niacinamide 10%, Salicylic Acid 2%, and Vitamin C 10%).

The website uses a clean, laboratory-like black and white design with signature amber glass dropper bottles and white tubes. Shoppers arrive on a homepage featuring an offer banner at the top, a predictive search bar, and navigation split into categories, skin concerns, and ingredients. Product cards show active percentages, ratings, prices, and direct “Add to Cart” buttons.

The central UX question for this study is: **how easily can everyday shoppers find the right skincare active for their skin type, understand how to use it safely without mixing conflicting chemicals, and complete a purchase with confidence?**

1–10: Core HCI / UX Parameter Analysis

1. Learnability & Onboarding

Rating: 8/10

The website follows standard e-commerce patterns like a top search bar, clear cart icon, and product grids, allowing first-time users to browse quickly.

- **Strengths:**
  - Familiar e-commerce layout with an accessible search bar and slide-over cart drawer.
  - Three clear browsing pathways: by Category, by Skin Concern (e.g. Acne), or by Ingredient.
- **Issues:**
  - Technical chemical names (such as “Ethyl Ascorbic Acid” or “LHA”) can confuse beginners who do not know skincare science.
- **Suggested Improvement:**
  - Add a 30-second skin quiz link on the homepage to recommend beginner-friendly starter routines.

2. Navigation & Information Architecture

Rating: 7/10

Multi-category navigation gives multiple ways to find products, but the dropdown menu is crowded.

- **Strengths:**
  - Users can navigate either by their problem (Acne, Dark Spots) or by the specific chemical active.
  - Breadcrumb links on product pages help users backtrack to parent categories easily.
- **Issues:**
  - The desktop dropdown menu lists over 40 links in dense columns, making it easy to misclick.
  - Mobile menu requires multiple nested taps to reach specific sub-categories.
- **Suggested Improvement:**
  - Simplify the mega-menu into clean tabbed categories and add thumb-friendly concern chips on mobile.

3. Usability & Interaction Efficiency

Rating: 7/10

Direct card purchasing and 1-click checkout streamline buying, but product comparison is difficult.

- **Strengths:**
  - Direct “Add to Cart” button on every product card saves browsing time.
  - Gokwik one-click checkout integration allows fast OTP-based ordering via UPI or Cards.
- **Issues:**
  - Users cannot compare two similar serums (like Niacinamide 10% vs 5%) side by side without opening multiple tabs.
  - No wishlist or 1-click reorder option in the customer account.
- **Suggested Improvement:**

- Add a quick comparison drawer for similar serums and introduce a wishlist feature.

4. Visual Hierarchy & Product Scannability

Rating: 7/10

Headings and primary buttons stand out clearly, but identical product packaging hurts scannability.

- **Strengths:**
  - Bold product titles and solid black “Add to Cart” buttons clearly guide the user’s eye.
  - Price and discount tags are prominent and easy to scan.
- **Issues:**
  - Because almost all serums use identical amber dropper bottles, users cannot easily tell products apart just by looking at photos in the grid.
- **Suggested Improvement:**
  - Add small color tags to product cards (e.g., Amber for Exfoliation, Blue for Hydration) to aid visual recognition.

5. Consistency & Standards

Rating: 7/10

Product cards and fonts are uniform, but promotional popups look out of place.

- **Strengths:**
  - Uniform product cards with consistent image dimensions, typography, and price styling.
  - Strict black-and-white theme across all main shopping templates.
- **Issues:**
  - Bright promotional discount banners sometimes clash with the brand’s clean clinical style.
- **Suggested Improvement:**
  - Standardize promotional graphics to match the brand’s minimalist, pharmaceutical aesthetic.

6. Error Prevention & Recovery

Rating: 6/10

Checkout inputs prevent typing mistakes, but there is no warning when users combine conflicting skincare chemicals.

- **Strengths:**
  - Checkout forms perform real-time validation on phone numbers and pin codes before payment.
  - Quantity adjusters (+ /) and remove buttons in the cart prevent accidental wrong orders.
- **Issues:**
  - Users can add conflicting active chemicals (like Retinol and high-strength peeling acids) to the cart without any warning about potential skin barrier damage.
- **Suggested Improvement:**
  - Add an automated Routine Compatibility alert in the cart (e.g., “Tip: Alternate Retinol and Salicylic Acid across different nights”).

7. Feedback & System Status

Rating: 7/10

The cart drawer gives immediate feedback on addition, but out-of-stock items could be clearer.

- **Strengths:**
  - Cart drawer slides open instantly when an item is added, showing updated subtotal and item count.
  - Free gift progress bar dynamically shows how much more to spend to unlock free items.
- **Issues:**
  - Out-of-stock items only show a slightly faded button without clear restock information.
- **Suggested Improvement:**

- Show an explicit “Notify Me When Available” button on sold-out products.

8. Accessibility & Content Readability

Rating: 6.5/10

Main text contrast is sharp, but small disclaimers and dense ingredient lists create reading strain.

- **Strengths:**
  - High contrast between primary black text and white background (`#111827` on `#FFFFFF`).
  - “How to Use” sections provide simple AM/PM icons and step numbers.
- **Issues:**
  - Secondary gray text (like disclaimers and strikethrough prices) is too faint.
  - The full ingredient list is a dense paragraph of Latin chemical names that is hard for ordinary buyers to understand.
- **Suggested Improvement:**
  - Darken secondary gray text for better contrast and format chemical lists into a simple “Decoded Ingredients” table.

9. Trust, Credibility & Transparency

Rating: 8.5/10

Ingredient percentages and customer reviews provide strong trust.

- **Strengths:**
  - Full active percentages (like 2% or 10%) printed openly on bottles and product titles.
  - Thousands of verified buyer reviews with star ratings and photos.
  - Secure payment badges (UPI, SSL) displayed clearly at checkout.
- **Issues:**
  - Strikethrough discounts on almost every product can make original prices feel artificial.

- **Suggested Improvement:**
  - Emphasize transparent honest pricing rather than permanent discount tags.

10. Aesthetic & Minimalist Design

Rating: 8/10

The website matches its brand name with an uncluttered layout, though corner widgets add noise.

- **Strengths:**
  - Generous white space and clean typography reflect the brand's scientific identity.
  - Product descriptions focus on facts and clinical data rather than cosmetic hype.
- **Issues:**
  - Floating WhatsApp chat badges and reward popups crowd the bottom corner of mobile screens.
- **Suggested Improvement:**
  - Group floating chat and reward icons into a single compact button.

Parameter Table

#	Parameter	Rating	Key Observation
1	Learnability & Onboarding	8/10	Familiar e-commerce layout; chemical names need beginner guidance.
2	Navigation & Information Architecture	7/10	Multi-category taxonomy works well; desktop dropdown menu is crowded.
3	Usability & Interaction Efficiency	7/10	Direct Add-to-Cart and Gokwik fast checkout work well; lacks product compare.
4	Visual Hierarchy & Scannability	7/10	Clear typography and buttons; identical amber bottles look too similar.

#	Parameter	Rating	Key Observation
5	Consistency & Standards	7/10	Uniform product cards; promotional banners clash with clinical branding.
6	Error Prevention & Recovery	6/10	Good checkout validation; **no warning** for conflicting active chemicals in cart.
7	Feedback & System Status	7/10	Cart drawer updates dynamically; out-of-stock status needs improvement.
8	Accessibility & Readability	6.5/10	Main text contrast is good; secondary text is faint; chemical lists are dense.
9	Trust, Credibility & Transparency	8.5/10	Excellent active percentage disclosures, clinical trial data, and verified reviews.
10	Aesthetic & Minimalist Design	8/10	Clean, uncluttered layout; corner popup widgets crowd mobile viewports.
AVG	**Average Score**	**7.2 / 10**	**Strong on scientific trust, search, and checkout; weaker on routine conflict safety and bottle differentiation.**

Golden Rules (Shneiderman)

Golden Rule	Rating	Website-Based Example
1. Strive for Consistency	Partially followed	Product cards follow one layout, but promotional discount popups break the clean styling.
2. Seek Universal Usability	Partially followed	Mobile layout works well, but faint gray text and auto-moving banners reduce accessibility.
3. Offer Informative Feedback	Followed well	Cart drawer opens instantly and shows item count, price subtotal, and gift spend progress.
4. Design Dialogs to Yield Closure	Followed well	Clear shopping path from card to cart to Gokwik 1-click checkout with order

Golden Rule	Rating	Website-Based Example
		confirmation.
5. Prevent Errors	Needs improvement	Users can buy conflicting actives (like Retinol + AHA Peel) together without any routine warning.
6. Permit Easy Reversal of Actions	Followed well	Quantity steppers and remove buttons in the cart drawer make fixing mistakes easy.
7. Keep Users in Control	Partially followed	Users control search and filters, but auto-moving banners lack manual pause controls.
8. Reduce Short-Term Memory Load	Followed well	Persistent search bar, cart badge count, and breadcrumbs keep user context clear.

Summary of Problems

1. **Conflicting Active Ingredient Blindness:** The cart allows users to purchase conflicting chemicals together without warning them about skin irritation risks.
2. **Identical Product Bottle Appearance:** Amber dropper bottles look almost identical in product grids, making visual scanning slow.
3. **Chemical Jargon Barrier:** Novice shoppers struggle to know which chemical active solves everyday concerns like pimples or dark spots.
4. **Floating Popup Widget Clutter:** Sticky chat icons and discount popups crowd mobile screens.
5. **Faint Secondary Text Contrast:** Light gray disclaimers and strikethrough prices fail contrast standards.
6. **No Native Product Comparison:** Users cannot easily compare two similar serums on the same page.
7. **Crowded Dropdown Menu:** The desktop navigation menu contains too many links in dense columns.
8. **No Saved Skin Profile:** The site does not let users save their skin type to highlight matching products.

Recommendations

1. **Add a Routine Compatibility Checker:** Show a gentle alert in the cart if conflicting actives (like Retinol and BHA) are added together.
2. **Add Visual Category Tags:** Put small color tags on product cards (e.g., Amber for Exfoliation, Blue for Hydration) to help distinguish bottles.
3. **Introduce a 30-Second Skin Quiz:** Place a quick quiz link on the homepage to recommend beginner-friendly 3-step routines.
4. **Clean Up Floating Popups:** Combine floating support and rewards icons into a single neat corner button.
5. **Improve Contrast & Readability:** Darken faint gray text and format dense chemical lists into a clean decoded table.
6. **Add a Product Comparison Tool:** Allow users to compare ingredients, pH, and skin suitability for up to 3 serums.
7. **Simplify the Main Menu:** Group dropdown menu links into clear, simplified tabs.
8. **Allow Saved Skin Preferences:** Let logged-in users save their skin type to highlight matching products automatically.

Note on Sources

Observations in this assignment are based on the live website of **Be Minimalist** (`https://beminimalist.co/`), reviewed in October 2026 on desktop and mobile browsers. Ratings reflect perceived usability and heuristic evaluations.

Conclusion

Be Minimalist has a credible, well-trusted store with transparent formulations and fair pricing. Its main challenge is balancing clinical transparency with beginner-friendly guidance. Adding simple routine safety checks, small visual tags on product cards, and a quick skin quiz will make the website significantly more intuitive and user-friendly for everyday shoppers.